Gulf of Tonkin Resolution

U.S. Congress · Joint Resolution H.J. Res. 1145 · approved August 10, 1964

Source: Gulf of Tonkin Resolution (Aug. 7, 1964), text via the Avalon Project, Yale Law School. Public domain.

Following reported attacks on U.S. destroyers in the Gulf of Tonkin off North Vietnam, Congress passed this resolution by a vote of 416-0 in the House and 88-2 in the Senate. It gave Lyndon Johnson sweeping authorization to use military force in Southeast Asia without a formal declaration of war. Later investigations (and the 1971 Pentagon Papers) revealed that the second of the two reported attacks likely never happened. The resolution was repealed in 1971 amid debate over the Vietnam War, and helped prompt the 1973 War Powers Resolution.

Connect: The Gulf of Tonkin Resolution expanded presidential war powers without a formal declaration of war. Compare with WWI (April 1917 declaration) and Iraq 2003 (AUMF). What's the pattern?

Key Passages

Johnson's message to Congress

> Last night I announced to the American people that the North Vietnamese regime had conducted further deliberate attacks against U.S. naval vessels operating in international waters, and I had therefore directed air action against gunboats and supporting facilities used in these hostile operations.

No wider war

> As I have repeatedly made clear, the United States intends no rashness, and seeks no wider war. We must make it clear to all that the United States is united in its determination to bring about the end of Communist subversion and aggression in the area.

The Resolution

> That the Congress approves and supports the determination of the President, as Commander in Chief, to take all necessary measures to repel any armed attack against the forces of the United States and to prevent further aggression. … the United States is, therefore, prepared, as the President determines, to take all necessary steps, including the use of armed force, to assist any member or protocol state of the Southeast Asia Collective Defense Treaty requesting assistance in defense of its freedom. Section 3. This resolution shall expire when the President shall determine that the peace and security of the area is reasonably assured

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Cold War containment in Vietnam; reported North Vietnamese attacks on U.S. destroyers in the Gulf of Tonkin in August 1964.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	The president, the military, North Vietnam, and the American public; it was voted on by Congress.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Congress, accepting the Johnson administration's account of the attacks; antiwar critics and later evidence questioned that account.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. HIPP — antiwar documents: Compare the wartime expansion of executive power in 1964 with similar moments (1898, 1917, 1941, 2001).
2. Why is this resolution sometimes called a ‘blank check’ for war?
3. Identify ONE specific consequence of the resolution’s later repeal.